THE SKATE

KICK



Kick flip

Slide

Pop Shove it

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The birth of skateboarding coincides with the launch of the first commercial color television sets. Discover the greatest skater movies of all time.

The world's first skateboard movie was launched in 1966.
Since then, the action sports and film industry has released several successful motion pictures with skaters turned actors and actresses.
With the advent of analog videotape, skateboard companies and skaters started creating their own productions.
However, there's a difference between skate videos and skate movies.
A skate video is usually a short segment of edited clips featuring recreational, amateur, or pro riders produced and released by skateboarding companies, skate magazines, skate shops, and independent skateboarders.
A skate movie is a feature-length film or documentary that has been officially released on VHS, DVD, or through mainstream video streaming services.



When we think of "skateboard movies", we tend to think of the DIY video montages released by skate brands and often filmed by skaters themselves. The kind of short films you'd be able to nab on VHS from your local skate shop, and which has been slowly going defunct alongside the rise of TikTok and everyone now being able to film their own well choreographed lines on their phone.
But, sometimes, skate culture ends up being captured in the mainstream film world, too. It's not easy – too often skateboard movies, both docs and dramas, can end up being cringe or not reflective of the lives of actual skateboarders. But there are a few that have nailed it, or made us think, or used skateboarding as a launching pad to get into something else entirely. Here are the ultimate films and docs about skateboarding out there, ranked.



Paranoid Park

In Gus Van Sant's latest film *Paranoid Park*, the prolific director wastes no time in drawing us into the world he creates. But what is so fabulous about this world is that it doesn't seem created at all, but wholly organic, as if Van Sant just stumbled across it and set up a camera to capture what he saw.

Through the performances of the mostly non-professional cast (Taylor Momsen, as Alex's girlfriend, has been around for a while though...my how far Cindy Lou Who has come), Paranoid Park captures the essence of high school life better than most teen movies could ever dream. Van Sant achieved a similar feat in the Palme D'Or winning Elephant five years ago, but despite some truly beautiful moments in that film I have never really been a fan of it. Here, however, Van Sant has achieved something very close to breathtaking. The blurred images of soaring skateboarders that repeat throughout the film take on a hauntingly surreal beauty, almost as if they are a foggy notion of what Alex could one day achieve, or something he sees begin to fade away as a tragic accident changes his life forever.

In *Paranoid Park* the camera is a window to the soul, and cinematographer Christopher Doyle (*In the Mood for Love, Hero*) treats it as such. It allows images to linger in the mind and sink slowly in, like a lingering sunset or a flowing river. And through his lens, Paranoid Park becomes a place we all remember, where a frightened little boy growing up in an ever changing world must learn to deal with things he doesn't always understand or know how to handle. It is teenage life seen through a horrific situation to amplify that unspoken fear that we all feel, but precious few know how to articulate.

Mid90s

It's a coming-of-age film in its way. Stevie (played by Sunny Suljic) is a 12-year-old in 90s Los Angeles from an unhappy family. He lives with his single mom Dabney (Katherine Waterston) and his boorish elder brother Ian – an atypically brutish Lucas Hedges – who bullies Stevie with punches that Hill cranks up on the soundtrack so the impact sounds like a bone snapping.

One summer, Stevie finds himself hanging out at a skateboard shop with the kind of laid-back proto-hoodlums who are the stuff of his mother's nightmares: Ruben (Gio Galicia), Fuckshit (Olan Prenatt), Ray (Na-kel Smith) and Fourth Grade (Ryder McLaughlin). Hill himself may identify with young Stevie, or perhaps with Fourth Grade who is forever filming everyone with his video camera and is shyly embarrassed about his own career hopes, modestly announcing he may just follow in his dad's footsteps at the Department of Motor Vehicles.

Hill shows how the skaters are to be Stevie's alternative family, and when his charm and courageous skating cause him to be lavishly accepted by these cool kids five years older than he is, it causes sibling rivalry with Ruben, an envy made worse by his precocious sexual success with a much older girl (a wish-fulfilment scene that male directors often go in for). Ray is the group's de facto leader, and when he appears to be disloyally drifting away from them for some older and yet cooler skaters, it creates something akin to a power vacuum, filled by Fuckshit, who masks his hurt feelings by drinking even more than usual, and is, worryingly, the group's.



Dogtown and Z-Boys

There are those who believe that documentary's place is on the small screen. Dogtown And Z Boys effortlessly proves them wrong – factual movies can be as exciting, slick and accessible as any other species of celluloid.
Stacy Peralta's film is an exuberant, nostalgic paean to a time, place and a lifestyle. A founding member of the Zephyr Team (Z Boys), Peralta traces the history of the skateboard from its early years as a stalled '60s fad, through to his friends' reinvention of it as an extreme sport with marketing deals and corporate sponsorship. Quite a trip for an activity that only began when the inventive beach-bums found themselves with nothing to do when the surf blew out mid-morning.
There's an engaging rebelliousness to the use of California's infrastructure – the towering waves of playground asphalt and the empty swimming pools of the vacationing middle classes – for a purely hedonistic kick. Peralta matches that kinetic creativity with dynamic, imaginative use of his archival material.
His camera hurtles across the still images, while Sean Penn's deadpan narration, complete with coughs and splutters, is perfectly pitched. It's hardly an unbiased film – it concludes with a sell-out to corporate America and the gentrification of Dogtown's once seedy beachfront. But who doesn't re-edit their own history?

Quite possibly the best documentary about youth and sport since Hoop Dreams

What comes across most poignantly in Peralto's minor masterpiece is the sheer joy of being a member of the coolest gang on the beach, as remembered – and embellished – by a generation of fortysomethings for whom, you suspect, life has never been anywhere nearly as good. A genuine must-see.has many hand held shots and the zoom is employed more, creating a rough, jerky portrayal. Stacey Peralta being the strangely responsible one with a job has straight on, clean cut shots. Tony Alva, however, our most competitive Z-boy by far is filmed often from below, giving him a larger than life presence.



Lords of Dogtown

A hanging-out movie thats as close as youll ever get to soaking up the time.

Hot on the wheels of skateboarding documentary Dogtown And Z-Boys comes Hollywood's fictional version of the same true story – a reflection of a reflection of reality. Is that a '360 Kickflip' too many for the judges? No, because, if anything, Lords Of Dogtown gives a more vivid impression of what it must have been like to hang out with the coolest kids on the block. As an insider from the original Zephyr Team, Stacy Peralta was in prime position to source matchless archive footage and one-on-one interviews for his documentary. Peralta's screenplay credit guarantees authenticity here, but Catherine Hardwicke – director of Thirteen – plays to different strengths, emphasising mood, drama and acting. In her hands, Heath Ledger delivers his first truly adult performance as burnt-out hippie Skip Engblom, while Emile Hersch nudges the young ensemble cast into deeper and darker emotional territory as troubled skater Jay Adams.



"Lords of Dogtown" follows the rise and inevitable fall of the team, efficiently conveying the events with a flat accuracy that emphasizes history over character development. Director Catherine Hardwicke ("Thirteen") does an outstanding job of re-creating the seedy '70s atmosphere so much so that you could be forgiven for assuming you were watching archival outtakes from "Z-Boys." Hardwicke really nails that sense of post-Vietnam, rejection of authority of SoCal.
Hardwicke also understands the thrilling nature of speed for these kids. She employs a point-of-view camera from a skateboard's wheel to convey the rush. Hardwicke's most important achievement, however, was how she portrayed that skating was indeed these boys life. You really could see how skating for character Jay Adams was an outlet for the psychological pain he was experiencing. Hardwicke was very devoted to her character's individual portrayals. She has 3 contrasting personalities of main characters and shows this also through camera techniques. Jay being the more kinesthetic, hard, "go-go-go" character has many hand held shots and the zoom is employed more, creating a rough, jerky portrayal. Stacey Peralta being the strangely responsible one with a job has straight on, clean cut shots. Tony Alva, however, our most competitive Z-boy by far is filmed often from below, giving him a larger than life presence.

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